
Bankers, Businessmen and the Cultural Cold War: Networks of Transatlantic Cultural Associationism

Giulia Clarizia*¹

¹Roma Tre University – Italy

Abstract

In the aftermath of the Second World War, Western Europe and the United States witnessed a proliferation of private initiatives aimed at promoting transatlantic relations. As the ideological tensions of the early Cold War began to emerge, cultural initiatives acquired particular prominence (Krabbendam and Scott-Smith, 2003). These initiatives were often elitist in nature and involved not only intellectual and political actors, but also leading figures from the worlds of finance and business. (Laville, 2006).

This paper is part of a broader research project investigating the role of Italian financial elites in the construction of transatlantic relations in the postwar period (1945–1960), with particular attention to cultural activities as a channel of interaction. The paper focuses on the methodological use of graph-based network analysis to reconstruct and study the networks of transatlantic cultural associations.(Grandjean;Jacomy, 2019). Special emphasis is placed on the analytical value of membership lists of association boards, frequently found on official letterheads. These sources are often the most immediate-and in some cases the only-available evidence for reconstructing the composition of governing bodies within transatlantic cultural organizations.

By applying network analysis to these materials, the paper reflects on how this approach offers an original and effective analytical framework for studying transatlantic cultural associational life, shedding new light on the involvement of financial and entrepreneurial elites in these networks. Through the visualization and examination of intertwined boards and personal connections, the paper highlights patterns of influence, circulation of elites, and institutional overlap.

The case studies examined include the U.S.-based Council on Foreign Relations, the American Committee on United Europe, the World Brotherhood and the Rockefeller Foundation. With specific regard to Italian–American relations, the analysis focuses also on the America–Italy Society and the Associazione Italo-Americana. Together, these cases illustrate the central role of financial elites in shaping postwar transatlantic cultural and political exchange beyond traditional diplomatic channels.

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*Speaker

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